

“Just another day in that one corner in a restaurant we were supposed to be dining in.”

There is a restaurant at the edge of a nameless street that no map could ever find. I return to it often in my mind, though I have long forgotten how I first arrived there. Its sign hangs crooked above the door, flickering gold against the midnight rain, and every time I step inside, the bell above the entrance rings the same lonely note—as if it has been waiting only for me.

The restaurant smells of burnt sugar, coffee left too long on the warmer, and the faint trace of old perfume clinging onto velvet curtains. Time does not move there. The clocks on the walls remain

frozen at 7:13, their hands stiff with dust, while candle wax drips endlessly without ever reaching the table. Somewhere in the corner, a vinyl record crackles with the same soft piano melody, skipping every few seconds like a memory that cannot continue forward.

I always sit at the booth beside the rain-speckled window. The leather seat is cracked beneath my fingertips, and the table still bears the ring stains from forgotten glasses. Outside, headlights smear against the wet pavement like watercolor paint, but no cars ever truly pass by. It feels less like a street and more like the idea of one—a world paused just beyond reach.

The waiters never seem surprised to see me. They glide silently between tables carrying untouched plates of food that steam forever in the dim amber light. Each dish reminds me of someone who once sat across from me, someone who arrived warmly and left quietly, like all people eventually do.

There was the bitter espresso served in delicate porcelain cups—the kind that burned the tongue at first sip. It reminded me of people who loved sharply and briefly, arriving in my life with intensity before disappearing just as quickly. Then there were bowls of sweet tomato soup paired with fresh bread, comforting and familiar, like the friends who promised permanence but slowly drifted into silence over time.

Some meals were extravagant: steaks dressed in rosemary butter, sparkling wine poured into crystal glasses, desserts dusted with gold sugar. Those reminded me of temporary happiness, beautiful enough to make me believe they would last forever. But expensive things fade too. Even the richest flavors vanish after the final bite.

And yet, no matter how many dishes arrived at my table, I searched for yours.

Yours was simple. A plate of fries stolen from the edge of mine. Coffee with too much cream because you hated bitterness. Strawberry cheesecake you claimed was “too sweet,” though you always finished the slice anyway. It was never really about the food. It was the way your laughter filled the empty spaces between clinking glasses and distant conversations. Somehow, even the dullest meals felt complete beside you.

Now every plate tastes unfinished.

The waiters continue bringing dishes I have never ordered, as if the restaurant itself wants me to move on. New flavors. New company. New memories trying desperately to replace the old ones. Sometimes strangers sit across from me for a while, carrying the scent of fresh beginnings. They tell stories, laugh softly, and almost convince me that life outside this restaurant still exists.

Almost.

Because every time the door opens, my heart betrays me.

For one fleeting second, beneath the dim golden lights and the sound of rain against the windows, I still hope it will be you walking back in. I still imagine your coat damp from the storm, your tired smile finding mine across the room, your voice apologizing for taking so long.

But the bell above the door rings, and it is always someone else.

And lately, for the first time, I think I have begun preparing myself to leave. I notice the door more often now than the empty seat across from me. I fold the napkin carefully after every meal, as though practicing goodbye. Sometimes I even stand when the rain softens outside, my fingers brushing against my coat, wondering what kind of world still waits beyond the restaurant windows. Perhaps there are streets untouched by memory. Perhaps there are tables where my heart no longer searches every stranger for your face.

Still, leaving feels like betrayal.

It's as if leaving would be my final act of love—the only proof that I loved you enough to stop haunting the place where your absence still lives. Because perhaps love is not always waiting. Perhaps sometimes it is knowing when to rise from the table, when to let the untouched coffee grow cold, when to finally walk toward the door without looking back.

And maybe the cruelest part is this: a part of me still believes that the moment I leave will be the exact moment you return.

Yet I keep my hand on the edge of the table anyway, quietly teaching myself how to let go of the only place where I can still pretend you never truly left.

So I remain there, night after night, while untouched meals grow cold beneath the candlelight. The restaurant continues serving people who come and go, each one leaving behind another empty chair, another fading taste, another reminder that nothing ever truly stays.

Except me.

Still sitting in the same corner.

Still searching for your face in every stranger.

Still waiting, right where you left me.